posts in imperial, princely, or great amiri contingents'. Single cavalrymen and ahadis were the backbone of the army and received a decent salary of about 200 rupees a year. 'Theirs was an honourable profession in Mughal India,' writes Blake, 'and both ahadis and cavalrymen were respectable men in Muslim society.' The men holding ranks upto 500 were all called mansabdars while those from 500 to 2500 were called amirs and those from 2,500 and above were amir-e-azam.

Akbar had already divided his empire into subahs, sarkars, and mahals and he would now replicate exactly the entire administrative structure of one subah with another, so that they would be virtually identical from one end of the empire to the other. Because of the expense involved in maintaining the designated numbers of horses, elephants, and camels for a mansabdar, there was a temptation by officers to present animals that might not actually belong to them and receive pay for the non-existent animals. Some officers went to remarkable lengths to pass off 'borrowed' men and animals as their own, as described by Badauni:

> …Amirs did as they pleased…[putting] most of their own servants and mounted attendants into soldiers' clothes, brought them to musters… Hence…a lot of low tradespeople, weavers and cotton-cleaners, carpenters, and green-grocers, both Hindu and Musulman…brought borrowed horses, got them branded, and were appointed to a command…and when a few days afterwards no trace was to be found of the imaginary horse and the visionary saddle, they had to perform their duties on foot.

So Akbar also introduced a system of dagh, or branding of horses, to prevent corruption in the muster of animals. All mansabdars were now required to brand their animals and present themselves to Akbar with the exact number of horses that corresponded to their numerical rank.

The mansabdari system was equally applied to Hindu chieftains, in a move that co-opted these men into the Mughal Empire and made them equally invested in its success. Under earlier sultans, Hindu chiefs were required to raise a peshkash, a payment of tribute, and to supply an army whenever required. This peshkash was usually raised by the chieftains by taxing their dependants, and could be debilitating for the peasantry. Now the chieftains were incorporated into the mansabdari system, being steadily promoted and gaining more honours as they provided loyal service to the